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Human trafficking—it happens here

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Editor's note: Human trafficking is a scourge on society—and it's happening in our own backyard.

A Fresno man was recently sentenced to more than 15 years in prison after pleading guilty to human trafficking involving a minor, crimes that included a stop in Camarillo.

July 30 marks World Day Against Trafficking in Persons. In recognition, and after recent backlash over Sacramento's handling of a law pertaining to penalties for human traffickers, we invited input from two sides: Democratic Assembly member Jacqui Irwin and John Andersen of the Ventura County Republican Party.

By Jacqui Irwin

Special to the Acorn

Human trafficking remains a serious issue in California, and the fight against human trafficking requires unity and a shared commitment from law enforcement, lawmakers, community leaders and the public.

As an elected official, I have been very active on this issue throughout my tenure in the Assembly and in local government. I currently serve on the Ventura County Human Trafficking Task Force leadership advisory committee; I've authored legislation on the issue; and my office has partnered with various organizations over the years to host events for the public to draw attention to the fight against human trafficking.

We are very fortunate in Ventura County that the sheriff's office, in partnership with Interface and the Human Trafficking Task Force, has been highly successful in identifying, investigating and prosecuting those responsible for human trafficking throughout the county. These entities also support victims through referrals to organizations that provide services that aim to break the cycle of trafficking.

The work done in the Legislature on human trafficking doesn't always make the news. For example, the Assembly's budget this year included $46 million for prevention efforts and services to human trafficking victims.

This sort of preventive work can be extremely impactful, but may not generate any news stories. Last week, however, human trafficking was in the headlines. Senate Bill 14, authored by Sen. Shannon Grove (R-Bakersfield), seeks to add human trafficking to the list of "serious felonies" and make the crime eligible under California's three-strikes law.

Earlier this year, the bill received unanimous support in the Senate before moving over to the Assembly. The bill was heard but failed in the Assembly Public Safety Committee. The resulting backlash was predictable and understandable given the nature of this heinous crime.

Thankfully, at the very next Assembly session, I voted to move the bill back to the Public Safety Committee, where it was ultimately passed.

Criminal justice reform is a debate worthy of discussion, but there are certain crimes that warrant the harshest of sentences. Among them is the trafficking of human beings.

As a citizen and a legislator, I am in complete agreement with the intent of Senate Bill 14. As a result, I have added my name to the list of co-authors of the bill and look forward to the day the bill makes its way to the Assembly floor,

where I will cast my vote to send it to the governor's desk.

Assembly member Jacqui Irwin represents the 42nd Assembly District, which includes Thousand Oaks, Moorpark, Simi Valley, Agoura Hills, Westlake Village, Calabasas and portions of Camarillo.

By John Andersen

Special to the Acorn

The movie "Sound of Freedom," which looks at child sex trafficking, is one of the most popular movies right now. Its mantra: "God's children are not for sale."

Unfortunately, you wouldn't know that by watching our Assembly members in Sacramento.

The Assembly Public Safety Committee recently voted 2-6 on party lines to shoot down Senate Bill 14, which would increase the penalties for child sex trafficking.

After public uproar, Assembly Republicans attempted to bring the bill, which had the support of Gov. Gavin Newsom, to the floor for a vote. But Democrats refused and referred it back to the Assembly Public Safety Committee.

When Ventura County's legislators had a chance to take a stand against a $32-billion industry, they each refused to take the action needed to protect our kids, proving again how out of touch our Democratic legislators truly are.

Assembly members Jacqui Irwin (D-Thousand Oaks) and Jesse Gabriel (D-Woodland Hills) couldn't even be bothered to do the job we pay them to do, as neither voted on the motion to bring the bill to the Assembly floor for a vote. Irwin then had the audacity to claim on social media that she "voted . . . to require the Assembly

Public Safety (Committee) to rehear the bill," even though she didn't bother actually casting a vote.

Thankfully, when the bill was reheard in the Assembly Public Safety Committee, enough Democrats found a conscience and voted with the committee's Republicans to advance it. Now, it moves to the Assembly Appropriations Committee.

How will Ventura County's legislators vote when the bill comes back to the full Assembly? Will they support children or pedophiles? It's hard to know for sure. At the very least, Irwin is good at sticking her finger in the air to see which way the wind is blowing.

Regardless of her claims, concerned citizens might want to call the offices of their Assembly members and urge them to support this important bill.

Next year, the voters in Ventura County will again have a chance to show how they feel about protecting our children. Hopefully, voters send the message that Ventura County will not support elected officials who look like they support child sex traffickers over our children.

It's time to restore some sanity to Sacramento by replacing these ineffective representatives with candidates who will work to keep our children safe from predators who deal deadly drugs and traffic children for sex.

John Andersen is a former trustee of Conejo Valley Unified School District and serves as chair of the Ventura County Republican Party.

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